

Jim, [received 19-4-14]

I found a little stash of files with information about Gordon Pask's Colloquy of Mobiles (attached). The excellent photo (Pask_Colloquy.jpg) and the other jpg files were provided by someone (I think in Germany) writing a book on Pask (or on cybernetic art in general) who had heard of my connection with him. As I have dates on the files, I can at least backtrack to see if I have any saved email from that time. If I find it, I'll pass on the contact.

The final file (Recollections) was a pleasant surprise as I'd completely forgotten writing it. It includes a fairly good description of the Colloquy which is (I think) easier to read than Gordon's description in the jpg's. Gordon's prose tends to be hard work to disentangle, so I suggest you read Recollections (after viewing the photo) before trying to make something of Gordon's sometimes convoluted prose. I was relieved to see that what I wrote then (which even includes a mention of Peter's Cybernetic Serendipity exhibit) is entirely consistent in time line and details with the notes I've already provided to you. This doesn't confirm that they are accurate, but at least suggests that my memory hasn't been further corrupted by the last nine or ten years.

I'll add some additional details here (which, I assume, were already known or of minimal interest to my original interlocutor). They are probably best read after "Recollections".

I started out to write just a few additional explanatory notes, but got carried away (and it was fun). But you may find some of the extraneous detail entertaining.

Gordon was the perfect image of a mad professor. He looked and dressed like a shorter version of a cross between the second and third Dr Who's – dark curly hair, and invariably a dark suit and bow tie. He had a lot of "rituals" (which we'd now call OCD) including lucky colours, lucky ways to walk around the table in his office, lucky resistor values, and a lucky tin for his pipe tobacco with a lucky screwdriver to ream the pipe. His pipe was used to disconcerting effect. While talking he would spend a long time getting it lighted (which allowed him a lot of uninterruptable pauses) and when it was fully alight and glowing would (usually at an especially obscure point in what he was talking about) plunge it into his suit pocket. No-one who hadn't seen this often before (typically one of his research sponsors) could concentrate on anything but waiting for him to burst into flames. Which he didn't because his tailor provided a specially reinforced pocket. There is a nice picture of Gordon from 1990 at <http://www.cyberneticians.com/slideshow/gordon-pask.htm> at home in Richmond. Unfortunately it is rather low definition, but (delightfully) it is pretty clear that he is in the act of lighting his pipe.

Gordon had a particular genius for converting his sometimes obscure ideas into relatively simple concrete representations of them. Till I joined him these had (where something mechanized was needed) been limited to electro-mechanical devices (those uniselectors and relays again) built by his long-time assistant Tony Watts. I was able to add electronics for the cases where electro-mechanical devices couldn't easily cope (too complicated, slow, or noisy). Quite a lot of what we did (I didn't displace Tony) was (like the Colloquy) a hybrid of electronic and electro-mechanical components.

Gordon's devices weren't always entirely electrical/electronic. One research project (sadly before my time, but the equipment was still around in the lab) for the US Office of Naval Research (ONR) simulated a population of cellular automata (think "Game of Life"). This involved a big wooden frame holding a large number of cans suspended on springs. Water

from an overhead tank was fed to the cans via flexible tubes which could be closed off by relays. Water flowing into a can would weigh it down and stretch the spring, until this closed a contact which would feed signals back to open and close various relays depending on how a complicated plug board was set up, and there were lights indicating the state of the relays (essentially, the output). Now that I think about it, the cans must have had drain holes (smaller than the feed tubes), so that they would eventually empty when their relay closed and cut off the inward flow. I'm told (pity I missed it) that when the ONR sponsor came over from Brussels, where he was based, to review progress, the overhead tank burst and drenched him – even more distracting than Gordon's pipe.

Mad professor or not, he was a good and supportive employer. Around the time of Cybernetic Serendipity he suggested that it was time I got an education (I had poor A-levels and no degree). When I found the University of Sussex Experimental Psychology MSc course, which was intended as an accelerated conversion course for students with a good first degree in another subject "or equivalent qualification", he very actively supported the application, which probably tipped the balance toward my acceptance. Although Sussex were, at the time, granting entrance to undergraduate courses to mature students without the necessary formal qualifications, this was a first for a post-graduate course (and maybe the last – but not because I didn't do OK).

Yolanda Sonnabend, cited in the material on Colloquy as the designer of the "female" mobiles, was (and is) a stage designer. Gordon probably encountered Yolanda through Joan Littlewood (theatre director – "Oh what a Lovely War" and much more) who he knew because of his involvement in the Fun Palace project (see <http://www.theguardian.com/culture-professionals-network/culture-professionals-blog/2014/jan/06/fun-palaces-joan-littlewood-culture>). Yolanda (NOT for any publication) was something of a science groupie, and formed relationships (some romantic, some not) with several eminent scientists and technologists including Jim Watson (Crick and Watson), C H Waddington, the evolutionary biologist, and Seymour Papert, co-director (with Marvin Minsky) of the MIT Artificial Intelligence Lab. Yolanda introduced me to Seymour around the time of Cybernetic Serendipity (I think he had come to London specifically to see it – and probably also to see Yolanda). My recollection is that we spent a couple of solid days talking (likely an exaggeration). I do remember that we tried to go for lunch to a very upmarket fish restaurant (Wheelers, I think) near the ICA, but were denied entrance because we were insufficiently formally dressed. Sometime during that extended conversation, Seymour suggested that I come out to MIT to work for him, but at that point I was already set up to start the Sussex MSc, and said I'd contact him when that was over and see if the offer still stood. Which is what I did, and it did, so that was how I ended up at MIT as a Research Assistant (essentially a graduate student, except they paid me rather than me paying them).

Recollections also mentions Pip and Adele Youngman as the builders of Yolanda's design for the female fiberglass figures (a very messy process). Pip was a self-described inventor and Soho petty criminal who I'd known since I was a teenager haunting Soho pubs, coffee bars, especially the left wing Partisan coffee house which was just under the offices of the Universities and Left Review (originally edited by Stuart Hall, who died recently, so there have been quite a few articles about him and his legacy), and folk song venues. In my first real job, which was working for a couple of nutty scientologists (one of them, Cyril Vosper, later wrote a comprehensive exposé of scientology) who had somehow got a contract from a chain of car parks to build a machine to issue time-stamped tickets (actually, hole punched) and then compute the parking fee on exit, I recruited Pip (mainly for the "inventor" part of his skills) to build the mechanical components needed. We set up a

workshop in Fitzrovia and did what we could (I was building the electronics, but building a card punch from scratch was non-trivial) until – predictably – the money ran out.

When Gordon and Yolanda needed the fiberglass figures built, the funding (which came from a slightly shady businessman, Maurice Hyams) wouldn't run to going to the sort of company which built custom fiberglass shapes from customer designs, so I recruited Pip (and Adele who, as it were, came along for free) to build them. As you can see from the photo, this worked out quite well.

Mark